



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
CORNELL JOHNSON

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

Johnson at Cornell has deployed a number of sweeping initiatives over the past few years, including a re-vamp of its curriculum and the launch of a new NYC campus. It also merged the business school with its schools of Applied Economics and Hotel Administration, enabling Johnson to pool resources, increase student choice and open new channels for collaboration.

Johnson puts a premium on small class size, engaged professors and its close-knit community. It combines business fundamentals with a strong emphasis on applied learning, individually focused study, leadership development, and intense collaboration. Yet the class is also wrapped in the academic universe of Cornell University, the largest Ivy League in the US, located in upstate New York.

Johnson's new dual campus identity allows MBAs to decamp the cloistered college town of Ithaca for a semester in NYC, drawing comparisons to INSEAD's dual campuses in Fontainebleau and Singapore. Currently housed in Google's Chelsea office, the NYC-based Cornell Tech campus relocated in 2017 to a two million square foot facility on Roosevelt Island. The program features a one-year tech-driven, studio-structured curriculum where students operate in cross-functional teams to develop solutions for nearby tech giants, with resources to commercialize their ideas.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Accounting, Corporate Social Responsibility/Ethics, Tech

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 1,600
Admissions Selectivity: 33%
Total Tuition: \$132,580

MBA Class Size: 279
Yield: 52.84%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Consulting 22%; Financial Services 29%; Technology 18%; Consumer Products 10%
Top Recruiters: EY, Amazon, Guggenheim Securities, IBM, Barclays PricewaterhouseCoopers, McKinsey

Avg. Base Salary: \$125,578

Employment in 3 months: 94%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek		7	-	13	16	16	13	10
Financial Times							17	27
Forbes	-	9	-	10	-	10	-	9
The Economist		15	17	23	23	28	26	14
US News	16	16	17	16	14	16	15	15

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs
Int'l Students: 33%

Avg. GMAT: 700
Female Students: 31%

Avg. GPA: 3.39

Deadlines for 2019-2020:

R1 - Oct. 8 '19

R2 - Nov. 5, '19

R3 - Jan. 8, '20

R4 - April 8, '20 *test scores can be submitted until June 1

Sources: Johnson Cornell, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, Forbes, The Economist, US News, MBA50

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ESSAYS 2019-2020

Candidates applying for 2019-20 admission are required to complete a Goals Statement as well as two essays.

Goals Statement:

Use this short answer question to succinctly share your short and long term goals. If invited to interview, you will have the opportunity to elaborate further and should be prepared to connect your prior experience with your future aspirations.

A statement of your goals will begin a conversation that will last throughout the admissions process and guide your steps during the MBA program and experience. To the best of your understanding today, please share your short and long term goals by completing the following sentences and answering the enclosed short answer question (350 words maximum):

Immediately post-MBA, my goal is to work as a(n) ____ [Role] ____ at ____ [Company] ____ within ____ [Industry] ____.

Targeted Job Role:

Target Job Company:

Industry:

In 5 – 10 years post-MBA, my goal is to work as a(n) ____ [Role] ____ at ____ [Company] ____ within ____ [Industry] ____.

Targeted Job Role:

Target Job Company:

Industry:

How has your experience prepared and encouraged you to pursue these goals?

Impact Essay:

This essay is designed to explore the intersection of engagement and community culture. Whether during the program or following graduation, our students and alumni share a desire to positively impact the organizations and communities they serve. To help you explore your potential for impact, we encourage you to engage with our students, alumni, faculty, and professional staff. You may choose to connect with them via email or phone or in person during one of our on campus or off campus events. As you seek their input and insight, please be respectful of their time and prepare a few discussion points or questions in advance.

At Cornell, our students and alumni share a desire to positively impact the organizations and communities they serve. How do you intend to make an impact during the next several years of your education and/or career? (350 words maximum)

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Back of the Resume Essay:

This essay is an opportunity to present yourself as an individual. We encourage you to think about your proudest accomplishments, interests and passions, and personal highlights that will help us to get to know you as a person and potential community member. We value creativity and authenticity and encourage you to approach this essay with your unique style. Alternative submission formats may include a slide presentation, links to pre-existing media (personal website, digital portfolio, YouTube, etc.), as well as visually enhanced written submissions. Maximum file size is 5 MB. If you choose to submit a written essay, please limit your submission to 350 words or fewer. Multimedia submissions should be under 3 minutes.

The front page of your resume has given us a sense of your professional experience and accomplishments as well as your academic summary and extracurricular involvement. If the back page reflects "the rest of your story," please help us get to know you better by sharing ONE example of a life experience, achievement, or passion that will give us a sense of who you are as a potential community member.

Optional Essay:

You may use this essay to call attention to items needing clarification and to add additional details to any aspects of your application that do not accurately reflect your potential for success at Johnson (350 words maximum).

If you are reapplying for admission, please use this essay to indicate how you have strengthened your application and candidacy since the last time you applied for admission. Please also review our Admissions Policy for additional information about re-applying (350 words maximum).

Roy H. Park Leadership Fellows Essay

The Roy H. Park Leadership Fellows Program is a two-year full tuition fellowship award for Two-Year MBA candidates in Ithaca who have demonstrated outstanding leadership potential and who are committed to making an impact within their communities. Each year it is awarded to up to 25 incoming students, with the expectation that they will participate in additional leadership and personal development activities outside of our regular curriculum, serve in leadership roles within the school, and complete a public service project by the time they graduate. The Park Fellowship is only available to U.S. citizens applying for the Two-Year MBA program.

What is your greatest example of leadership and what personal qualities helped you succeed in that role? Please limit your submission to 500 words or fewer.

View this terrific article by Fortuna's Randall Johnson, former Cornell Johnson Assistant Dean of Admissions, on [Writing Cornell Johnson's 'Back of the Resume' Essay](#).

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By Randall Sawyer

Randall served as Assistant Dean of Admissions, Financial Aid and Inclusion at Cornell's The Johnson School. During his tenure, Randall and his ADCOM team reviewed and decided nearly 15,000 applications; increased the school's GMAT average and median beyond 700-threshold for the first time ever; enrolled a record number of women and under-represented minorities; and experienced the best selectivity and yield results in the history of the school.

Tip #1 - Answer the question

This seems like a simple notion, but many applications are denied because the applicant tells the Johnson Admissions Committee the message they want to get across, and in doing so, sometimes do not answer the question. In those cases, the applicant is already in trouble in the first essay! The best way to make sure you answered the question correctly is to share the body of your answer with a friend you trust and ask them what the question was based on your answer. If they match, well done. If they don't, rewrite until they match! Also, be clear and concise and count words. Candidates have been declined because they could not follow directions.

Tip #2 - Have a plan for your short-term and long-term goals

Quality in and quality out is important to all b-schools. At Cornell, the Admissions Office and Career Services Office want to make sure that you know where you want to go and how you are going to get there. Everyone knows that ambitions can evolve, but make sure you can draw reasonable lines from what you are doing now through where you will be once you earn your MBA. For example, it is tough to take an IT person and make them an Investment Banker, but the MBA can take the IT person and make them a consultant working in the tech space. Be prepared to discuss this transition in the interview process and have a Plan B if Plan A does not work out.

Tip #3 - Visit and know the Johnson School, its people and its culture.

Cornell is not just building a class; it's building a community. What do you bring to the table to add to that community? The program is based on class discussion, interaction and *teamwork*. If these three things make you nervous or uncomfortable, don't apply to Cornell. Ithaca, in the bucolic Finger Lakes region of New York state, is a unique place where you'll spend many months, so make sure the location, culture and community resonate with you. The best way to gauge this is to visit the campus, sit in on a class and speak with Johnson Ambassadors and faculty. When you visit, speak to some of the students in the Atrium and ask them hard questions – politely of course – what they like and don't like, why they chose Cornell, what would they change if they could. By the end of the day you'll have a feeling in your gut about whether Johnson is a fit for you, or not. Trust that feeling and act accordingly. If you feel like it's a mutual fit, then go for it – it is an amazing place for the right people. If not, then you've learned a valuable lesson – Cornell knows it isn't for everyone and they're ok with that (and you should be, too).

Tip #4 - Be authentic, be authentic, be authentic.

Write the application in your own voice, not someone else's. Accept advice from others who look at your application, but don't let them edit your work until it has lost your voice or style. Tell the Johnson ADCOM about you and your life, career, passions and why you are interested in Cornell. Do not tell them what you think they want to hear. Be honest, forthright and professional – Cornell is looking for those people.

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Tip #5 - Be creative on the back of the resume essay/PowerPoint/video.

This is an opportunity to be you without many boundaries. Be unique, tell a story, draw/take a picture, make a video, stand-out with something funny, scary, honest, vulnerable, extraordinary. For example, one applicant's video made the difference by displaying a dazzling unique differentiator: While his application was solid, his experience was typical, but when his training as a classical pianist was revealed in a video performance, he surprised everyone on the team (no one would have guessed it). Not only did he get in, I remember the video more than a decade later. Another memorable essay was submitted by a soldier stationed in a war zone, who provided the chapter headings for a book of his life. It was written to his two daughters, as if he was not returning from war. It was vulnerable, profound and creative, bringing everyone who read it on the ADCOM to tears, which left us eager to meet him in person. Johnson is giving you the opportunity to make this part of the application anything you want it to be.

Tip #6 - Use the optional essay if you need to.

This is a difficult decision for many, and understandably so. Only use it to highlight something you NEED to address. Think a low GPA, a failed class, being terminated from a position with cause, a gap in your resume, a run-in with the law – stuff like that. Everyone makes mistakes, and if yours requires an explanation, then give it. DO NOT repeat what has been said elsewhere in the application.

Tip #7 - Let your application age and hit submit.

When you are finished with the application, don't think about it for a few days. Let it age – get away from it and clear your mind. Go back to it when you are well rested and review it with a critical eye. Make the necessary changes and let it rest again. You will know when it is the best document you can provide that shows the Johnson ADCOM who you are, who you want to be and how Cornell is going to influence the rest of your career and life. Ask one or two friends to give it a look and then submit it. Relax and wait for the Johnson School interview email to arrive!

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at FortunaAdmissions.com
